

Publication: Efficacy of Cognitive Behavioral Therapy for Generalized Anxiety Disorder -- A Randomized Controlled Trial

Authors

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Abstract

This randomized controlled trial evaluated the efficacy of cognitive behavioral therapy for adults with generalized anxiety disorder.

Methods

****Participants:**** We enrolled 200 adults aged 18-65 meeting DSM-5 criteria for GAD. Participants were recruited from community mental health centers. A total of 153 participants completed the study (76.5% retention).

****Intervention:**** Participants received 12 weekly sessions of manualized CBT (n=100) or were assigned to a waitlist control (n=100).

****Primary Outcome:**** State-Trait Anxiety Inventory (STAI), measured at 12 weeks post-randomization. The STAI is a 20-item self-report measure of state and trait anxiety.

****Secondary Outcomes:****

****Analysis:**** Independent samples t-test comparing CBT vs. waitlist on STAI change scores. Effect sizes reported as Cohen's d. No multiple comparison corrections applied. Software: SPSS 28.

Results

The CBT group showed significantly greater reduction in STAI scores compared to waitlist (mean difference = -8.4, 95% CI [-12.1, -4.7], $t(151)=4.52$, $p<0.001$, $d=0.74$). No significant differences were found for PHQ-9 ($p=0.08$) or PSS ($p=0.12$).

Conclusions

CBT is an effective treatment for generalized anxiety disorder, producing large improvements in anxiety symptoms. These findings support the use of CBT as a first-line treatment for GAD.